

Lab: Reading and Sharing Stitch Notation

Objective

Practice encoding and decoding crochet knowledge through different communication channels — written instructions, charts, and demonstrations — and experience how information quality changes with each medium.

Materials

- Worsted weight yarn, approximately 30 yards
- Crochet hook, size H/8 (5.0mm)
- Blank paper and pen (for writing patterns and drawing charts)
- A crochet circle partner (required for Parts 3 and 4)
- Scissors
- Optional: colored pencils for chart drawing

Steps

Part 1: Decoding — Written Pattern to Fabric (15 minutes)

1. Without discussing it with your partner, crochet the following pattern exactly as written:
2. Ch 15.
3. Row 1: Sc in 2nd ch from hook, *ch 1, skip 1 ch, sc in next ch*, repeat * to * across. (7 sc, 7 ch-1 spaces)
4. Row 2: Ch 1, turn. Sc in first sc, *ch 1, skip ch-1 sp, sc in next sc*, repeat across.
5. Rows 3-6: Repeat Row 2.
6. When finished, set your swatch aside.

Part 2: Encoding — Fabric to Written Pattern (15 minutes)

1. Crochet a small swatch of your own design (at least 4 rows, using at least 2 different stitch types). Do not tell your partner what you are making.

2. Once your swatch is complete, write a pattern for it in standard notation. Use proper abbreviations (sc, dc, ch, etc.), stitch counts in parentheses, and asterisks for repeats.
3. Review your pattern: could someone who did not see you crochet it reproduce the swatch from your instructions alone?

Part 3: Communication Test — Partner Exchange (15 minutes)

1. Exchange written patterns with your partner (not the swatches — only the written instructions).
2. Each person crochets the other's pattern.
3. When both are done, compare the original swatch to the partner's reproduction. How closely do they match?
4. Discuss any discrepancies. Were they caused by:
5. Ambiguous instructions? (communication encoding error)
6. Misreading of instructions? (decoding error)
7. Different tension or gauge? (model calibration difference)

Part 4: Demonstration vs. Written (10 minutes)

1. Choose a stitch or technique that one partner knows and the other does not.
2. First, the knowledgeable partner writes a brief instruction for the stitch without demonstrating.
3. The learner attempts the stitch from the written instruction only. Record: how successful was the first attempt?
4. Now the knowledgeable partner demonstrates the stitch in person, showing hand positions and explaining as they go.
5. The learner attempts the stitch again. Record: how did the demonstration improve the outcome compared to written instructions alone?

Part 5: Chart Drawing (Optional, 10 minutes)

1. Using standard crochet symbols (+ for sc, T for dc, O for ch, dot for sl st), draw a symbol chart for the pattern from Part 1.
2. Compare your chart to the written pattern. Does the chart make the spatial structure of the pattern clearer? Is any information lost?

Discussion Questions

- During the partner exchange, what were the most common sources of miscommunication? How could the written patterns have been improved?
- When comparing written instructions to live demonstration, which aspects of the stitch were easier to convey in each medium?
- Did the symbol chart reveal any structural features of the pattern that were not obvious in the written form?
- How does this exercise change your understanding of what it takes to successfully communicate a crochet pattern?

Wrap-Up

You have practiced encoding, decoding, and transmitting crochet generative models through different communication channels. The mismatches and successes in the partner exchange illustrate the challenges and power of shared notation. Keep your written patterns and reproductions for discussion in the next crochet circle meeting.